

will go off for the person on call. You should acknowledge the incident within 5 minutes, or the person on second level support will be alerted. The PD incident will have the link to the corresponding Zendesk issue from where you will continue the conversation with the customer.

Once acknowledged, you need to login to Zendesk, go to the corresponding ticket and let the customer know that you will handle their case and send them a Zoom meeting link. If the customer is unable to access Zoom, you may need to use phone, Skype, WebEx or Hangouts. The full procedure for emergency tickets can be found [here](#).

Once the emergency has been resolved, return to the ticket in Zendesk and document any steps taken to resolve the issue.

Crisis Situations

If you are unable to help the customer and their instance is in a critical state (unavailable, uncertainty of data loss, etc.), you should escalate the PD incident to second level support, and work through the issue together. It may also be necessary to ask for assistance from a developer in the appropriate Slack channel. While you are waiting for help to join the call, focus on getting their server to a usable state.

If an emergency takes longer than an hour to resolve, and/or multiple people are or need to be involved, start a Google Doc that is open to the customer and the wider team at GitLab, and keep track of the issues and ideas there. Zendesk's 'linear' display of communication with a customer is not as effective in crisis situations, and the majority of developers do not have access to Zendesk in the first place. Announce the Google Doc in the appropriate Slack channel (production, development, whats-happening-at-gitlab) so that individuals can contribute solutions and ideas. When the crisis has been resolved, be sure to transfer pertinent know-how from the Google Doc to relevant documentation, handbooks, and/or issue trackers, so that the Google Doc can be deprecated a.s.a.p. In addition, Support Engineers and Developers involved in the crisis should make time to have a hangout for hand-off to make sure that everyone has the chance to recover and stay clear-headed.

Security Disclosures

We have a Responsible Disclosure Policy. Users who reach out to security@gitlab.com will now receive an auto-reply providing them with specific instructions for reporting the various types of security concerns, and the ticket will be automatically closed. There is more information on HackerOne [below](#).

Refer to working with Security for information on identifying and handling any open security tickets.

When in doubt, please involve the security team. This is really important to reduce the likelihood of a 0-day disclosure.

Issues created from ZenDesk tickets must follow the security issue triage process.

Reports that are PGP-encrypted will be handled by the Security Team.

HackerOne

We use HackerOne to manage security reports. The HackerOne program is managed by the Security Team. The complete workflow for handling HackerOne reports can be found on the Security Team page.

If a Team Member requires access to HackerOne, create an access request.

Support Tickets for customers on paid plans

Customer can submit support tickets via the Support Portal. The Support Team follows our workflow for Zendesk tickets to manage these.

Tickets can be submitted by customers on paid plans for either gitlab.com or self-managed.

Support for customers on free plans

For customers on free plans (.com 'Free' and self-managed 'core'), there is the GitLab forum. The Support Team does not currently work with the forum - the Developer Relations Team aims to answer questions there on a best-effort basis in conjunction with the wider community.

GitLab issue trackers

When an issue for either GitLab.com or self-managed installations is confirmed (bug, regression etc), it will be reported on the main GitLab project issue tracker. As a Support Team member, most issues will be reported here, however you might report issues in one of the other following areas listed below (based on the specific feature or product):

- GitLab Runner issue tracker for issues specific to GitLab Runners.
- GitLab Charts issue tracker for issues specific to GitLab Helm Charts.
- GitLab Omnibus issue tracker for issues specific to GitLab Omnibus.
- GitLab Documentation issue tracker for issues related to the docs site.

Non Channel Work

The Support Team also works to improve GitLab: write documentation, fix bugs, add features, and polish the website.

SECTION: support/data-analysis.md

Purpose

This page serves as the cornerstone for a Support Engineering data analysis community of practice.

Support team members who engage in any form of data extraction and analysis, either out of interest or as part of their work, can use this page to get an overview of ongoing planning and analysis efforts in the Support team, current methods of extracting and analyzing data, and figure out who to collaborate with on specific topics of interest.

As such, this page contains the following information:

- What's being measured, why it's being measured, and the data is retrieved.
- Who's responsible for it.
- Best practices around data collection and analysis.

How do these metrics differ from Performance Indicators?

The Customer Support Department Performance Indicators are formal metrics used to keep track of how well the Support team is doing as a whole.

The any parameters and metrics included in this page are for exploratory and internal planning purposes and should not be used for reporting on performance.

The Customer Support Department Performance Indicators are the single source of truth for those indicators and, in the case of conflict, prevails over any the content on this page.

Parameters

Support time segments

A common set of time segments Support team members can refer to when discussing topics which are bound to specific periods of the global day, such as support engineer availability and workload.

- DRI: Wei-Meng Lee (@weimeng)

The support time segments are based on each region's business hours as defined in Preferred Region for Support and were chosen to maximise overlap between region's segments, and to align with periods of high customer messages received per hour.

Note that these are time segments and not geographical segments. What's important is that we have folks available and actively working Support these hours. For this reason, the time segments were named "Early", "Middle" and "Late" instead of "East", "Central" and "West" to avoid any association with geographic locations.

Here are the time segments in tabular form:

Region	Anchor TZ	Local start	Local end	UTC start	UTC end	Length
AMER-Early	PT	05:00	09:00	13:00	17:00	4 hours
AMER-Middle	PT	09:00	13:00	17:00	21:00	4 hours
AMER-Late	PT	13:00	17:00	21:00	01:00	4 hours

APAC-Early AEST	09:00	12:00	23:00	02:00	3 hours
APAC-Middle AEST	12:00	16:00	02:00	06:00	4 hours
APAC-Late AEST	16:00	22:00	06:00	12:00	6 hours
EMEA-Early CET	08:00	14:00	07:00	13:00	6 hours
EMEA-Late CET	14:00	18:00	13:00	17:00	4 hours

Metrics

Customer wait time

"Customer Wait Time" is one of the Support Department's KPIs and is defined as the total amount of time the ticket spends in the "Open" and "New" states over a ticket's life cycle. Life cycle time is measured using "Total Time To Resolve".

- DRI: Ilia Kosenko (@lkosenko)

In Zendesk Explore, Customer Wait Time can be calculated using:

zendesk

VALUE(Requester wait time (hrs)) - VALUE(On-hold time (hrs))

Requester wait time (hrs) is used instead of Requester wait time - Business hours (hrs) because of the following reasons:

- While business hours does not count time elapsed on weekends, it also does not count time elapsed outside of a Preferred Region for Support's business hours.
- To align with Time to Resolution measurement, which does not use business hours for the same reason above.

Additionally, the median is used for reporting the Customer Wait Time KPI as this smooths over the extra time captured over weekends by using Requester wait time (hrs) instead of Requester wait time - Business hours (hrs).

We have chosen to exclude the "On-Hold" state from this metric as our view is that, when used properly, the Support team member handling the ticket would have agreed with the customer when a next update is to be expected. This means that the customer is not waiting without knowing when the next reply would come, and should not be considered as unnecessary wait time.

SECTION: support/gratis-support.md

Overview

GitLab Premium and Ultimate subscriptions include Customer Support. Free or expired users, and prospects, are not typically entitled to contact Customer Support with technical questions. Under certain circumstances, Sales or Customer Success team members may wish to request a

period of free support for a prospect or customer. This page describes the process for them to make such requests.

> Important Note: Gratis support requests are not for one-off technical problems, and they are not requests for help with a single ticket. They are meant for high-value situations where ongoing support may be needed over 30 days. See below for full descriptions of the intended valid scenarios.

Restrictions on gratis support

1. Only 30 Gratis Support items may exist at any one time. The current reference sheet containing who is receiving gratis support can be found here. The sheet can only be updated by Support Operations.

1. All requests for Gratis Support require approval from a manager within Sales or Customer Success. You must obtain approval prior to opening the request.

1. All requests are for 30 days at a time. The maximum allowance for Gratis Support is 90 days, requested in 30 day increments.

Gratis support for prospects and former/expired customers includes the following limitations:

1. Does not include emergency support.

1. Does not include upgrade assistance support.

1. Does not include namesquatting requests.

1. All response times are reasonable effort and will be given an internal SLO of 24 hours.

Further restrictions may exist depending on the type of Gratis Support you select below, and/or on the particular customer/prospect situation.

Requesting gratis support using the webform

The webform is available here: <https://gitlab-com.gitlab.io/support/support-ops/forms/gratis-support-request-form/>

If you have any questions or problems as you fill out the form, please ask in the support-operations Slack channel.

Required information

For all requests, you must provide the following:

1. Name of the manager within Sales or Customer Success who has already approved your request

1. Links to the Account and Opportunity within SFDC

1. Amount of ARR associated with the Opportunity

Some options require additional information as displayed in the webform for that option.

Options on the webform

The gratis support webform has the following options, which are described in detail in each section below.

a prospect

Please refer to the Priority Prospects page for more information.

a current customer migrating from one product to another

Use this when an existing customer is migrating from Self-managed to SaaS, or from SaaS to Self-managed. This step ensures that the customer receives support for both instances, not just the one that holds the valid subscription.

a customer trialing a higher tiered plan

Use this when an existing Premium customer wants to trial Ultimate features. This step ensures that the customer receives support on the Ultimate features, even though their subscription is only for Premium tier.

a former customer

Use this when a former or expired customer is trialing GitLab again (proof of value / POV) or is on a Trial/temp license during negotiations.

an extension of previously requested Gratis Support

Use this when you have already obtained gratis support (following one of the above options), and you need to request a 30-day extension.

a support leadership approved situation not covered by the above

Use this only when you have already negotiated a specific situation with Customer Support leadership team, and already have approval to make the request for gratis support. To discuss such a situation, post in supportleadership.

SECTION: support/on-call.md

On-call in GitLab Support

There are four on-call rotations in Support:

- Communications Manager on-call (CMOC) - in which Support Engineers drive public communication in the incident management process during GitLab.com operational emergencies.
- Customer Emergencies on-call (CEOC)- in which Support Engineers respond to and coordinate the resolution of emergency reports from Self-managed and GitLab.com customers
- US Government Emergencies - which is similar to Customer Emergencies, but has different hours and a US Citizen requirement to participate in
- Support Manager On-call (SMOC) - in which Support Managers are an escalation point for issues raised by Support Engineers and GitLab team members and missed PagerDuty notifications

For customers that have Priority Support, the Support Engineering Team is on-call in these

capacities and available to assist with emergencies. What constitutes an emergency is defined in our definitions of support impact.

We take on-call seriously. There are escalation policies in place so that if a first responder does not respond fast enough another team member or members is/are alerted. Such policies aren't expected to ever be triggered, but they cover extreme and unforeseeable circumstances.

Expectations for Support on-call

Be alert and available

When you are on call you are expected to be available and ready to respond to PagerDuty pings as soon as possible, and certainly within the emergency response time set by our Service Level Agreements (SLAs).

If you have plans outside of your work space while being on call, then being available may require bringing a laptop and reliable internet connection with you.

You should not be chained to your desk, but you should be equipped to acknowledge and act on PagerDuty alerts in a timely manner.

Be proactive in communicating your availability. Sometimes you can't be immediately available for every minute of your on-call shift. If you expect to be unavailable for a short period of time, send an FYI in Slack.

Prepare ahead of your shift

Before your scheduled on-call shift begins, check the Customer Events calendar for any customer activities to be aware of that may coincide with your shift. Familiarize yourself with the details of those events in case the customer ends up paging out for help.

Note: the Customer Events calendar is also linked at the top of the supportself-managed Slack channel for quick reference.

Communicate

Involve relevant stakeholders: whether it's the e-group, a CSM, an ASE (Assigned Support Engineer), subject matter experts or Support leadership, customer and operational emergencies should be known. See your rotation specific workflow for more detailed notes.

Note: You may sometimes be required to contact GitLab users on behalf of another GitLab team (such as the SIRT team). Please follow the Sending Notices workflow to action these requests.

Ask for help when needed

Rest assured: escalation is okay -- other GitLab team members are happy to help. Caring for our customers is a shared responsibility. Tag a Slack support-team Group if you haven't gotten help in your Slack thread. Tag the support managers if you need to escalate further.

If another support engineer joins your emergency call, feel free to assign them a role to

divide up the labor.

> So and so would you please (take notes, reach out to this product team and ask for help, look up the code for this and see what you can find)?

Take care of yourself

Make a real effort to de-stress during your on-call shift. After being on-call, consider taking time off, as noted in the main GitLab Handbook. Just being available for emergencies and outages causes stress, even if there are no pages. Resting is critical for proper functioning. Just let your team know.

When you get a notification from PagerDuty give yourself a few minutes to prepare.

- Get to someplace comfortable and quiet where you can devote your attention to the emergency.
- Take care of any biological needs.
- Grab a snack and some water.
- Breathe: you've got this.

When you're in a call, you do not need to provide immediate answers. You're allowed to pause for a few minutes for researching, asking for help, etc. Make sure to communicate -- let the other folks on the call know what you're doing. Example: "I need a few minutes to work through the code here and make sense of it".

Take a break

Consider taking breaks during emergency calls. Taking a break can help you to feel more refreshed while ensuring our customers get the best help we can provide.

At the beginning of the call, set expectations with the customer by letting them know you plan to take a break each 90 minutes (or so), if the call goes that long.

When the call begins, set a timer to count down and notify you that it's time for a break. (If you forget, observe the call duration in Zoom.)

When the timer goes off, summarize the current state, make sure everyone knows when the call will resume and how to join. If your timer expires but you're not at a reasonable stopping point, extend the timer by a small amount.

During the break:

- Stop actively working on the emergency
- Take care of yourself
- Step away from your working area
- Reflect on the current troubleshooting strategy, the goal, and other options or possible causes

A 15 minute break during active troubleshooting can be a good way to reset, and help your brain come up with new, creative ideas to solve the problem at hand.

While the break should be restorative, in some cases it can be helpful to use some of the break time to form a plan for what you plan to try next when the call resumes.

If you've had a long week with multiple pages from PagerDuty or particularly long calls, consider asking someone to cover a day or some portion of a day so you can get some rest.

How Support On-call works

Schedule and escalation policy

By using a regional, follow-the-sun style of on-call Support we try to keep rotations within waking hours.

As a result, each region may organize their on-call rotations in a slightly different way, or have different requirements for hours of coverage.

PagerDuty is the single source of truth for on-call hours, rotation order and escalation policies.

NOTE: If a new alert has not been acknowledged after 10 minutes, the Support Manager on-call is alerted. After a further 5 minutes, if there is no acknowledgement, Senior Support Managers are alerted.

There are several ways to view current and future schedules:

1. In PagerDuty: View the Customer Emergencies schedule (CEOC) and the escalation policy
1. In Google Calendar, subscribe to your on-call schedule
1. In the sptleaders-daily Slack channel, you can see who is on-call for the different schedules today
1. In the Support Pagerduty Worksheet, you may be able to see who will be on-call for future quarters.

Scheduling PagerDuty rotations

PagerDuty schedules for Support should be filled in by the Directly Responsible Individuals (DRIs) (such as readiness, support managers, etc.) directly on the Support PagerDuty Worksheet. The Readiness Team uses this sheet's contents to populate the following quarter's PagerDuty schedules during the first week of the final month of the quarter (Jan., Apr., Jul., Oct.). On the first Monday of the second month of a quarter the Readiness Team will post in the Slack supportleadership channel a reminder to the DRIs of the upcoming implementation due date.

Once the Readiness Team has implemented the next quarter's schedule they remove the scheduled rows from the sheet and PagerDuty becomes the SSOT for the next quarter. For dates that exceed the next quarter, the spreadsheet is the SSOT.

Availability

DRIs are free to use the spreadsheet to create the schedule in advance for up to one year from the current quarter. The schedule is not automatically populated and must be completely filled in for each quarter. If, at the time of Readiness implementation, there are blank spaces in one of the schedules, then the most relevant regional support director will be responsible for that shift until they find coverage and make an override in PagerDuty.

Schedule Changes

To make changes to the PagerDuty schedule, create a support team meta issue to discuss the changes with the affected participants. Once you decide on what changes to make, mention the support operations team in the issue to request that they implement those changes.

Your first on-call shift

For new team members approaching their first on-call shift, your Support onboarding issue includes a section suggesting that you shadow a current on-call to gain familiarity with the process. After completing your shadow shift, work with your manager to get yourself added to the on-call rotation. For your first on-call week we recommend asking your Onboarding Buddy to be available as a secondary to help if an emergency comes in.

Make the schedule work for you

Your role is to make sure someone is available to respond to emergencies during the week you are scheduled. Flexibility is possible -- you can split work with others, or schedule overrides for a few hours or days. You don't have to change vacation plans, or be at your desk all week! It's OK to take a walk outside, if you have your phone and reception. This way you can acknowledge the page, and locate someone to help (using Slack).

If you prefer to work with a colleague as a secondary, discuss with team members or your manager and find partners who like sharing the role. You can work together during the week, and update PagerDuty as you wish (options include: split days into mornings and evenings, take alternate days, work as a primary and secondary). Your manager can play an active role in helping pair people who want to work like this.

Swapping on-call duty

To swap on-call duty with a colleague:

- Check with your team, see who has availability, and get confirmation from the person willing to cover you. Generally, it's best to ask for help as far in advance as possible.
- If you're unable to find coverage, alert your manager.
- To swap an on-call shift, or temporarily replace someone, create an override on the main schedule in PagerDuty.
 1. Open the correct schedule in PagerDuty.
 1. Click on the relevant block of time in PagerDuty.
 1. Select "override" and fill in the name of the person you are swapping with.

See the PagerDuty documentation for complete steps.

Considerations in APAC

Shifts start on Tuesday and end on Monday

Due to the global on-call week starting on Monday, 09:00 Amsterdam time, on-call shifts for APAC begin on Tuesday and end on Monday. The APAC team has decided to retain this shift configuration as it allows for easier planning to

take a long weekend with Monday off and as a buffer to ease into the next on-call. See the latest discussion in this Support Team Meta issue.

Support Engineer shifts are 4-hour long shifts

APAC spans many timezones. Using an 8-hour shift to cover APAC business hours results in an on-call shift that can finish as late 9pm local time for APAC east based team members, and that starts as early as 04:30 local time for APAC west team members. Consequently the support engineer shifts are split into 2 groups, APAC 1 and APAC 2, allowing each team member to cover hours within their normal working hours.

Note that support manager on call shifts remain the full 8 hours.

Australia (Employees of GitLab PTY Ltd)

Team members employed by GitLab PTY Ltd must take time off in lieu within two weeks of completing their on-call shift. Time in lieu should be requested via Time Off by Deel, selecting the On-Call Time in Lieu option.

For more details, see the GitLab PTY Australia Specific Benefits page.

New Zealand (Employees of GitLab PTY Ltd NZ)

Team members employed by GitLab PTY Ltd NZ must avoid taking an on-call shift which falls on a New Zealand public holiday. If this cannot be avoided, your manager must be informed.

For more details, see the GitLab PTY Ltd NZ Specific Benefits page.

Starting on-call

Before your shift starts, always double-check that your alerts are working and your PagerDuty contact is up to date. Send a test page to make sure that you are receiving alerts correctly.

When your on-call shift starts, you should get notification(s) that your shift is starting (email or text, depending on your PagerDuty preferences).

Ending your on-call shift

Before your shift ends, consider what tasks need to be handed over and make sure to proactively communicate them to the next engineer in the rotation.

This may mean engaging the next On-call Support Engineer and bringing them into an active troubleshooting call, or it may mean providing instructions or context for situations you have handled that have some follow-up action. For example:

- If you're in an active call with a customer and it's time to end your day, page the incoming on-call and make sure they're prepared to provide continuity by giving them an overview of what's been done before and what's next

- Once you anticipate an active call to spill over into the next shift, you can try reaching out to the incoming on-call on Slack to make them aware of the upcoming need for a handover. As their shift has not yet started, they might not yet be available.

During an emergency taking a break, can be very beneficial for results for our customers as it permits the incoming CEOC to get up to speed. The outgoing and incoming CEOC benefit from discussing ideas in a low pressure environment.

- Advise the customer that the call will be paused, and agree on a time to reconvene.
- During the 30 minute break, discuss with the incoming CEOC:
 - What is the problem the customer is facing?
 - What activities have been performed?
 - What issues or theories have been ruled out?
 - What is the current theory of the source of the issue?
 - What alternative options have not been considered?
 - Does this emergency require an escalation?
 - What are the next steps?
 - What assumptions have been made, and what has not been considered?
- if a SaaS customer paged in looking for log analysis and we're waiting on the SIRT team, let the incoming on-call know and consider having them send a message in the ticket informing the customer of the handover
- if a customer is still in a heightened state and is monitoring after an outage and may page the on-call engineer, let the incoming on-call know
- if a SaaS incident ended and we're monitoring the queues for new customer reports, provide the incoming on-call engineer with a list of actions they should take

Generally: if there's a situation that occurred (or is actively happening) during your shift it's your responsibility to prepare the next on-call engineers.

Some rotations have specific handover procedures:

- CMOC - End of Shift Handover Procedure
- CEOC - Post-call

Viewing all on-call pages in one place

You may want to monitor all on-call pages received by the Support team. You can do this by joining the spton-call Slack channel.

Determining the On-call Support Engineer (CEOC)

To see who the current Support Engineer on-call is, you can:

- Look up who currently is a member of the @ceoc group/handle in Slack
- Log in to PagerDuty to view the Customer Support service
- View the sptleaders-daily Slack channel, the Support Team Bot messages list who is on-call for the different schedules today

To see who the upcoming Support Engineer on-call is, you can view the individual on-call schedules for:

- Customer Emergencies - APAC Group 1
- Customer Emergencies - APAC Group 2
- Customer Emergencies - EMEA
- Customer Emergencies - AMER Group 1
- Customer Emergencies - AMER Group 2
- Customer Emergencies - AMER Group 3

When in doubt, you can always ask in supportleadership.

Determining the On-call Manager

To see who the current manager on-call is, you can:

- Look up who currently is a member of the @support-manager-oncall group/handle in Slack
- Log in to PagerDuty to view the Support Managers service
- View the sptleaders-daily Slack channel, the Support Team Bot messages list who is on-call for the different schedules today

To see who the upcoming manager on-call is, you can view the individual on-call schedules for:

- Support Manager - APAC
- Support Manager - EMEA
- Support Manager - AMER

When in doubt, you can always ask in supportleadership.

Engaging the next On-call Support Engineer

In this context it is assumed that your shift has ended and the "next" Support Engineer on-call is the current one as far as PagerDuty is concerned. In that case:

You can ping the current Support Engineer On-call in Slack by tagging @ceoc.

You should page the Support Engineer On-call via PagerDuty

- immediately on a weekend or a holiday.
- if you don't get a reply to your Slack ping after ten minutes.

To page the current Support Engineer On-call, you can:

- Use the /pd trigger command in Slack to create a new incident (for the Customer Support service)
- Manually create a new incident from the Customer Support service

If your shift has not ended yet and you want to coordinate with the upcoming Support Engineer on-call, see determining the On-call Support Engineer.

Engaging the On-call Manager

In some situations, you may need to engage the Support Manager On-call for assistance.

You can ping the current Support Manager On-call in Slack by tagging @support-manager-oncall.

You should page the Support Manager On-call via PagerDuty

- immediately on a weekend or a holiday.
- if you don't get a reply to your Slack ping after ten minutes.

To page the current Support Manager On-call, you can trigger a PagerDuty alert:

1. Navigate to the supportleadership channel in Slack
1. Type /pd trigger and hit Enter
1. Write a summary in the Title field
1. Select Support Managers from the list of Impacted Services
1. Click Create to trigger alert.

Alternatively, create a new incident within PagerDuty, from the Support Managers service.

This is for engaging the current on-call manager. If you need to coordinate with the upcoming on-call manager, see determining the On-call Manager.

Mobile phone service and data reimbursement

We want to minimize the affect of on-call duty on your life. One way we do that is by offsetting any impact on your personal expenses.

You may expense the cost of your mobile phone service for any month that you are performing on-call duties. This is limited to your service cost itself, not any costs relating to the phone device, to a personal hotspot device or to services for other people on your phone plan.

We understand you may have plans outside of your normal workspace while you're on-call. If as a result you need to use your phone to provide internet service to your computer, then you may include additional data charges in your expense report.

Keeping the PagerDuty contact up to date

PagerDuty phone and SMS notifications can come from a variety of different phone numbers and as such, it is important to stay up to date with this to avoid missed pages. You should use this PagerDuty documentation page to download the most recent vCard or setup an automatically updated PagerDuty contact on your device.

If you use a "do not disturb" mode on your device, you should also allow the PagerDuty contact to bypass this.

SECTION: support/performance-indicators.md

{{% performance-indicators "customersupportdepartment" "Customer Support Department" %}}

SECTION: support/priority_prospects.md

Overview

By default, trial licenses do not include support.

As a member of the Sales/CS team, if you have a prospect who wishes to have access to GitLab Customer Support as part of their trial or Proof of Value, you can request temporary support for their trial license. This program is for strategically important prospects, and eligibility must be considered by Sales leadership. Generally, prospects with potential ARR of less than \$100,000 are not likely to be approved.

NOTE: This option is solely for prospects where the account type in Salesforce is Prospect. This cannot be applied to any type of account other than Prospect. For any other account, please see our main handbook page on Requesting Gratis Support.

Restrictions on gratis support for prospects

All general policies in the statement of support apply to prospect support.

- Only 30 prospects/customers can receive gratis support at any one time. The current reference sheet can be found [here](#) (internal link).
- An area sales manager must pre-approve any request for gratis support.
- The period of gratis support is limited to 30 days per request.
- No more than 2 extension requests can be made for a prospect (total 90 days).
- If the prospect converts to customer status, they will automatically get the proper support associated with their subscription purchase.

The following support specialties are excluded from gratis support for prospects:

- emergency support
- upgrade assistance
- migration assistance
- architecture review
- namesquatting requests
- for PoVs, support is limited to resolving errors from a setup (and not the setup process itself)
- All response times are reasonable effort, with an internal SLO of 24 hours.

Limitations within Zendesk:

- A maximum of 3 named contacts are able to create support tickets for the organization.
- Gratis support does not include shared organization setup in Zendesk.

How to request support for a prospect

Please follow the instructions on our main handbook page for Requesting Gratis Support.

How to request an extension

NOTE: Please file extensions one week prior to the expiration date, to avoid interruptions in service.

Please follow the instructions on our main handbook page for Requesting Gratis Support.

Information for the prospect

The prospect should never submit a support ticket before gratis-support process is fully completed

(as indicated by Support Operations in the gratis support request issue). Doing so can result in tickets being rejected.

After the process is fully completed, the prospect should be informed of the following vital information for submitting tickets:

- All tickets must be filed by one of the 3 named contacts provided in the request. Any others will be rejected by the system, and the tickets automatically closed.
- All tickets must specify "Sales Assisted Trial" in the "Tell us about your GitLab subscription" field. Any other option can cause routing problems.
- All SaaS related tickets should be submitted via this form, unless it is specifically about SaaS Account related matters
- All SaaS Account related matters should be submitted via this form
- All Self-Managed related tickets should be submitted via this form

SECTION: support/providing_excellent_customer_service.md

Understanding customer needs

If a customer asks a question, make sure you fully understand the reason for their question and what is the end result they are looking for. There may be a different and better way to achieve their desired end result, so always feel comfortable asking 'why'.

Understanding business impact

While waiting for a resolution to this ticket, is the user's business being affected?

If you don't know the answer to this, make sure you check with the user early on in the life of the ticket to prevent the ticket becoming an escalation.

Understanding the timescales the user is working to will help you set expectations and help them meet or adjust project timescales.

Managing expectations

When you send a user an update, the normal action is to set the ticket status to Pending, which indicates that you are waiting for a reply from them.

You might consider setting an expectation with the customer that you'll check back with them after an appropriate amount of time to ensure continued progress.

You may also set the ticket status to On-Hold, indicating that you are taking some action and will follow up with the user at a later time.

When putting a ticket On-Hold, you should:

- Inform the user when to expect your follow-up message.
- Invite them to inform you if your chosen schedule does not meet their needs so that you can adjust your plans accordingly. See also Understanding Business Impact.
- Aim to provide updates daily, and no less than every four days, which is the On-Hold period length.

When setting a ticket to Pending or On-Hold, consider using our Due Date and Reminders apps to help you to meet commitments you make.

Avoiding giving concrete answers to "when can I expect feature / fix X?"

During the course of your ticket work you may link back to feature requests and bugs. While an issue with an assigned milestone may ship in the release indicated, do not promise that it will be. See more in our documentation style-guide.

Emotionally-charged tickets

When customers are putting negative emotions into ticket communications, refer to the handbook entry on how to keep a ticket moving toward resolution when emotions are getting involved for helpful tips and guidance.

A ticket is close to breaching; I need more time for my full reply

1. Please send the user a short message to update them on the action plan and set clear expectations. Doing this will not only prevent an SLA breach, it will very likely be well-received by the user. Remember, you don't need to have a full answer in order for your message to be useful.
1. When sending the short public reply, set the ticket status to On-hold or Open. On-hold is useful when waiting for information from another team. Open is useful when you want to keep the ticket visible to the rest of the Support team.
1. When you take the above action, keep your commitment and get back to the user on time and with a full reply including next steps. Keep in mind

that you've stopped the SLA clock, so it's up to you to respond on time. Do not take this action if you are not planning to be the one to follow up.

Merging tickets

WARNING: Any attached files in the to be merged tickets will be shared across the tickets. Everyone in CC on both of these tickets will receive the files.

If you're merging two of a user's tickets that are related or are duplicates, be sure to send a message letting them know what you've done and why. If you don't, it often causes confusion and they open follow-ups asking why it was closed without comment. Please note that your Zendesk signature will not be automatically applied to this message.

Splitting tickets

Sometimes, it emerges that a customer is dealing with multiple independent problems in a single ticket, or a user asks about a different problem in an existing ticket.

It's recommended to keep tickets focused on a single problem that's clearly described by the ticket Title. You are encouraged to "split" the ticket by creating a new ticket on behalf of the user.

The new ticket should focus on a single issue and keep the original ticket on the original issue. This helps reduce time to resolution and makes it easier for us to focus on fixing the problem at hand.

Please see option 3 in Requesting Support for Customers for details on how to create a new ticket.

Removing Information From Tickets

We ask users to send us logs and other files that are crucial in helping us solve the problems they are experiencing. If a user requests deletion of information shared in a support ticket, or if we suspect sensitive information was accidentally shared, the information can be deleted using a Zendesk feature. Redaction is not reversible.

To delete text or attachments from a ticket:

1. Follow the steps in Zendesk documentation.
1. Let the user know what actions you have taken and why. Request the user to rotate any secrets that may have been shared.

If you don't see the option to redact, it is likely that you are not assigned to one of the authorized roles (you can check your role in Zendesk profile). In this case, please reach out to supportoperations or supportleadership in Slack to request deletion. Zendesk roles that have access to redact:

- Admin
- GitLab Staff
- GitLab Staff - Explore
- Security Staff
- Support Managers
- Support Staff
- Support Staff - CMOC
- Support Staff - Explore

Handling tickets created by GitLab team members

Every now and then, a GitLab team member will forward a support request from a customer, prospective customer, user, etc. These requests then appear as tickets from the team member, instead of from the original requestor.

Always reply directly to the original requester, keeping the person who forwarded it in the CC. You will need to manually alter the "Requester" field of the ticket, by clicking on the "(change)" link next to the email address of the apparent requester in the ticket title.

Please see Requesting Support for Customers for more details.

Communications

Document your work; provide all context

Add research notes to your tickets, as it's important that we clearly document all of our work performed throughout a ticket's lifecycle. Not only is this a good way for you to track your own progress, particularly for lengthy and challenging tickets, but it also provides your colleagues with a clear understanding of what has been tried thus far, and enables a smoother transition if a ticket needs to be reassigned.

Copying contents of Slack discussions to internal notes

When using Slack to work with others or communicate internally regarding a support ticket, please bear in mind our chat retention policy and the Communication Guidelines (esp. 9.).

It's best for future searches in Zendesk to copy relevant advice, notes, ideas, etc. from Slack to an internal note in Zendesk.

Closure summary

If you are the assignee of a ticket, and the customer has confirmed that the solution you provided has resolved the issue, add a closure summary to the ticket prior to changing the ticket status to solved.

The closure summary should provide a brief outline of the confirmed solution. It should be written with the goals of giving clarity to the customer with regard

to the solution as well as providing your colleagues with a quick and easy way to see what solved the customer's problem.

To make it easier for yourself to create a summary, please consider using the General::Closing Summary macro, which adds a template as an internal note populated with some information. You will then need only to fill in the remaining items with relevant information before copying the completed message to a public comment for the customer.

Some caveats to bear in mind:

1. You should add a closure summary if the ticket is a long ongoing ticket where multiple suggestions have been provided to the customer throughout the ticket lifecycle.
1. The macro template 'Closure Summary' is available in Zendesk to help guide you with formatting a closure summary, you can modify or remove template content as deemed necessary.
1. You should not feel the need to add a closure summary if the customer has not responded and the ticket has been automatically closed.
1. You should not feel the need to add a closure summary if the ticket has a short life span and the solution is easy identifiable from the ticket history. (For example: If the resolution was a simple link to documentation.)

SECTION: support/support-engineer-career-path.md

Career Development in Support

Exploring your passions and interests is just as important as focusing on a plan of short and long-term goals needed for any career development plan. Taking that time to explore, prepare, learn, and self-reflect can help ensure that you remain on track with where you ultimately want to grow.

While it's important to understand the how (how do I accomplish my goal? how do I get promoted?) and the what (what do I want to do? what do I need to do to get there? what do I still need to learn?), understanding the why is what becomes your ultimate driving force.

Promotions within the Support Department are guided by the Support Career Framework Matrix, following this track of role promotions. Consider the matrix (competency requirements) and promotion path as your expected baseline targets. Utilize the resources and recommendations in this document to explore your why, and to build your path to promotion with an extended view of what you can expect as you decide on your direction.

When you are ready to start building your promotion document, take a look at the Working on a Promotion support workflow. This will guide you on creating and completing your promotion document. You will find the link to the promotion document template on that page, and suggestions for what to include depending on what role you are seeking promotion to. You will also find links there to a list of completed promotion documents that you can refer to while building your own document. Ask your manager for guidance and feedback as necessary.

General Recommendations and Useful Resources (Applies to Any Promotion Path)

Familiarize yourself with what it means to plan your career path, and how leadership plays a role in your next step.

- Read about Career Development at GitLab.
- Read about Engineering Career Development at GitLab.
- Watch this video on the Critical Career Path Conversation.
- Read leadership books (strongly suggested).
- Watch this Engineering IC Leadership - Handbook Learning Session to understand the difference between IC leadership and Management.
- Schedule a coffee chat or AMA with someone in the position to better understand what they do, and ask for advice on how to work towards this role.
- Speak with your manager about available openings, and review spthiring for any opportunity announcements.
- Review and use the templates and resources available in the Career Development, Promotion, Performance, etc. Docs Templates folder to track your performance, career development, and path to promotion.
- As you begin to track and document your path to promotion document, use meaningful examples that highlight the relevant competencies and the type of work the promotion document asks for. See each section below for some specific conditions.

Path to Promotion: Intermediate Support Engineering

An Intermediate-level Support engineer uses strong communication techniques to understand customer situations, manage customer expectations, produce high quality ticket resolutions and create a consistently excellent customer experience. They demonstrate a personal growth mindset by initiating pairings, completing learning modules, and building product and troubleshooting knowledge.

Considerations and Recommendations

Recommendations to explore this path:

- Read about the Support Engineer role criteria.
- Read about the Intermediate level competencies and framework requirements.
- Watch or listen to the Ask Us Anything - Being/Becoming a Senior Support Engineer sessions from 2021-12.
- Watch or listen to the Async Staff Support Engineer AMA 2024.

Considerations when building your path:

- You consistently collaborate with the team and resolve tickets via email and customer calls.
- You create and update documentation based on customer interactions.
- You are willing to stretch yourself with new challenges, and learn to improve from setbacks versus settle for mediocrity.

Path to Promotion: Senior Support Engineering

A Senior-level Support engineer is a natural leader who has championed multiple areas of

technical skillsets required to resolve both intermediate and complex customer issues. Senior engineers are direct mentors of Support Engineers, and extend their contributions to other areas, such as contributing to documentation, bug fixes, workflow improvements, or engaging as the next point of escalation for technical issues.

Considerations and Recommendations

Recommendations to explore this path:

- Read about the Senior Support Engineer role criteria.
- Read about the Senior level competencies and framework requirements.
- Watch or listen to the Ask Us Anything - Being/Becoming a Senior Support Engineer sessions from 2021-12.
- Watch or listen to the Async Staff Support Engineer AMA 2024.

Considerations when building your path:

- You consistently collaborate with the team, and willingly jump in to help with critical escalations, customer calls, and emergency issues.
- You have the ability to influence positive change within the team.
- You support the growth of Support Engineers by frequently offering office hours and pairing sessions.
- You enjoy leading by example and look for ways to help improve various workflows, documentation, and training (including onboarding of new team members).
- You are willing to stretch yourself with new challenges, and learn to improve from setbacks versus settle for mediocrity.

Path to Promotion: Staff Engineering

Choosing to pursue a Staff-level role within the Support team involves an advanced level of technical skills that are often both broad and deep, in combination with leadership skills that help support and mentor other engineers. Staff Engineers lead by example, and often help to breakdown barriers between customers, Support, and other cross-functional teams by engaging in technical deep dives, contributing to bug fixes, contributing to feature enhancements, or providing product-improving recommendations.

Considerations and Recommendations

Recommendations to explore this path:

- Read about what staff level means at GitLab.
- Read about the Staff Support Engineer role criteria.
- Read about the Staff level competencies and framework requirements.
- Watch this discussion about becoming a Staff engineer.
- Watch or listen to the Group AMA - Being/Becoming a Staff Support Engineer - 2022-05-26.

Considerations when building your path:

- Consider projects you've led or have participated in, and how your contributions positively impacted the business, team, or customer.

- You consistently collaborate with engineers across multiple teams, and willingly jump in to help with critical escalations, customer calls, and emergency issues; you are known within the team as someone they can count on in difficult situations.
- You have the ability to influence positive change and improvements with the product, technology, and cross-functional team collaboration.
- You support the growth of both Support Engineers and Senior Support Engineers by offering frequent office hours, pairing sessions, and deep dive technical training sessions.
- You perform at a level that is consistent with a technical team lead, and proactively pursue opportunities to find areas of improvement that benefit the business, customers, and team members.
- You are willing to stretch yourself with new challenges, and engage in customer meetings to provide a level of support that sets the customer on the path to success.

Path to Promotion: Support Engineering Manager

People managers need a combination of skills involving not only technical credibility, but interpersonal and organizational skills in order to lead a team of diverse individuals. These skills include embodying the GitLab Values, coaching, interviewing and hiring, and thinking holistically about the Support team, how we fit within the company, and interact with users. People managers also need to have organizational awareness within GitLab, so you know where to look for answers and how to guide team members toward solutions. Read more about Leadership at GitLab.

Maintaining your technical skillsets becomes secondary, however you have the autonomy (and ability) to balance your level of technical skill upkeep with the priorities and needs of your team. Above all, you keep team members and our customers your top priority.

Recommendations and Considerations

Recommendations to explore this path:

- Read about what you can expect in a Support Engineering Manager role.
- Read about the Support Engineering Manager Responsibilities.
- Read about why candidates should apply for a Support Manager role to understand general expectations of this role.
- Read Transitioning from Individual Contributor to Manager.
- Read about Individual Contribution vs. Management and Trying the Management Track.
- Read about the Interim Manager role.
- Read about Elevate and consider participating.

Considerations when building your path:

- Consider experiences beyond what you have accomplished at GitLab (previous job experiences or even personal accomplishments) that can be used as supportive examples for building your case to transition into a manager role.
- You have the level of confidence needed to initiate change, address challenging situations, and make difficult decisions.
- You have the ability to show humility and accept pushback or failure with an eagerness to learn from them.
- You have the ability to accept accountability and ownership involving the support we provide

through guidance, leadership support, and assisting team members and the company to overcome challenges.

- You have the ability to influence positive change (improvements), starting at the individual level.
- You have the ability to build (not demand) trust and respect with team members; including not only peers and direct reports, but also team members and senior management across the organization.
- You have the deep desire to grow every team member you work with, using both empathy and open communication to maintain honesty in every line of feedback you give.

Looking Beyond Staff, Manager, and Support Roles

While this document is meant to primarily focus on career development opportunities for Support Engineering IC's, there are many other possible opportunities to pursue. This may include transfer option examples, or continued promotion opportunities that go beyond that of Staff and Support Engineering Manager, such as a Principal Engineer role, Senior Engineering Manager role, and Promotions to Director and above.

SECTION: support/support-engineer-responsibilities.md

Introduction

1. This page is an extension of the Support Engineer job family page.
1. This page should reflect the Support Career Framework.
1. The aim of this page is to help you to know what your responsibilities as a Support Engineer are.
1. You're not expected to work on all areas every week. Some of the areas have a frequency suggestion in parentheses after the heading title. This is to give you an idea of how often you might work in that area. Your manager will help you to know where to focus your efforts on a regular basis.
1. The 'What does success look like?' subsections help encourage consistent contributions across our global team. They're not hard targets that must be met. They're to help you know how and where to contribute to succeed in your role.
1. Performance measurement for annual reviews and promotions are separate activities to the core responsibilities described here.
 1. The People Group is responsible for the GitLab annual review process.
 1. Read about Support Engineer Career Path for further resources on promotions, and understanding the role at different levels.
1. Support Engineering has team level performance indicators. Successfully carrying out the responsibilities on this page will, directly or indirectly, help improve our KPIs. All team-level KPIs are, in turn, related to GitLab's company-level Objectives and Key Results.

Support Engineer Areas of Focus

We currently have two main areas of focus for Support Engineers:

1. GitLab - helping customers who encounter product-related problems on any of GitLab's platforms: gitlab.com, GitLab Dedicated or GitLab Self-Managed

1. License and Renewals - helping customers with License and Renewals problems

To view the team's current distribution among Areas of Focus, see our internal Support Team info site.

During onboarding, your initial area of focus will be made clear.

When reading this page, keep in mind your current area of focus. This will help you locate the correct workflows and roles.

Core responsibility of a Support Engineer

The core responsibility of a GitLab Support Engineer is to deliver an excellent support experience to our customers on a daily basis by working with them to solve the problems and answer the questions that they present to us in support tickets.

This responsibility can be broken down into five key components:

1. Be appropriately available
1. Work with your region to meet our FRT SLA target
1. Maintain good progress through to resolution on all of your assigned tickets
1. Manage customer expectations and communicate thoroughly through tickets and calls
1. Help others to maintain progress on their tickets

As you read through the components, keep in mind that the focus of an Intermediate Support Engineer differs from that of a Senior Support Engineer:

- Intermediate: Focus is on managing and solving their assigned tickets
- Senior: Although managing and solving their own assigned tickets remains important, focus is on helping Intermediate Support Engineers to solve their assigned tickets both by assisting directly on tickets (pairing, internal notes, etc.) and by delivering training (mentoring, classes, videos, etc.).

1. Be appropriately available

As a customer support team, we are responsible for being available to support our customers according to the terms of their contract with us. Although asynchronous work and communication are preferred within GitLab overall, in Support Engineering there is always a business need to have enough people available at any given moment to deliver support.

Support Engineers are responsible for:

- Creating their work schedule with their manager
- Coordinating with others, such as their manager and their Support Pods, their day-to-day availability for ticket work
- Working with any Support Manager to take on higher-priority tasks (such as STARs or account

escalations) based on customer needs

2. Work with your region to meet our FRT SLA target

Our goal, as stated on the Support Performance Indicators page, is to provide a substantive (meaningful, helpful) first response within the time period specified by the Service Level Agreement we have with our customers on at least 95% of Priority Support tickets.

During each working day, each Support Engineer should work with their region, and with other regions as needed, to help all of Support to meet that goal. How?

1. Your region may have defined its own processes related to FRT. If so, please follow those. If not, then expect that each person in the region, including you, will be monitoring the global view throughout each day, taking tickets as they can, and calling out to the rest of the region when there are new tickets that others could take.
1. See our Working on Tickets page for guidance on finding and selecting tickets on which to work, assigning tickets, and providing a first response.

Triaging tickets

Everyone is responsible for Triaging tickets to make sure they have:

1. The correct ticket form (such as SaaS, if they're asking for GitLab.com support).
 1. The correct priority
 1. The correct 'Problem Type'
-
3. Maintain good progress through to resolution on all of your assigned tickets

This is really the heart of what Support Engineers do, and succeeding here requires a balanced application of technical and nontechnical skills. Support Engineers should always be working to enhance their skills in both areas, not only through formalized training (see the Support Training project), but also through pairing with others, taking challenging tickets, etc.

Here are a few tips for maintaining good progress:

1. Start your work on each ticket with a clear restatement of the problem as you understand it
1. If the customer brings up new problems and questions, let them know those will need to be addressed in additional tickets and that your focus will remain on the original problem or question
1. As soon as you're unclear on what your next steps should be, seek help. See our How to get help page for

details

1. If you are unsure of what message to deliver to the customer, or how to word the message to achieve a positive impact, seek help in the spthow-do-i-say Slack channel
1. Ensure that you update each ticket, and therefore each customer, no later than the due date you've set with them. To succeed in this:
 1. Keep your entire workload in mind as you set your action plan with the customer so that you can set a reasonable due date (and time) for your next update
 1. If you haven't completed the intended work by update time, let the customer know what progress you've made and then set a new update time
1. If your ticket is STARred during your business hours, work with the on-call manager and the person who submitted the STAR to help address any concerns.
 1. You are not expected to respond or engage in a STAR if you are unavailable (for example, you are on PTO or its after hours). When you are back online, review the STAR thread to ensure you're up to speed, and address any follow-up actions, if applicable.
4. Manage customer expectations and communicate thoroughly through tickets and calls

The Customer Service Skills module, which is included in the onboarding for all Support Engineers, is our best source of training and information for this topic. If you onboarded before this module existed, please familiarize yourself with its contents, either by going through the entire module or by selecting and viewing videos that address topics of interest to you. You might also want to grab the Ticket Management Quick Reference Guide from that module. Here's a quick reference to the quick reference guide:

- Understand the customer's real needs
- When you can't do what the customer wants, find what you can do to help them
- Keep the customer informed at all times about what you're doing and why
- With every interaction, clearly communicate the action plan including the due date and time for the next update from you
- Set, manage and reset expectations as things change

Although most of the time Support Engineers communicate with customers asynchronously (through support tickets), it's important to make use of synchronous communications, Zoom calls, whenever the situation calls for it, such as:

1. You're having trouble getting a clear understanding of the problem or request from the communications in the ticket
1. You believe the customer is not understanding your requests of them
1. The customer seems very anxious, frustrated, upset, or confused
1. The customer repeatedly asks for a call
1. Live troubleshooting and discussion are the best way to make progress toward resolution

See the Customer Calls page for our recommended practices and workflows for arranging, conducting and managing calls.

5. Help others to maintain progress on their tickets

Collaboration is one of GitLab's values, and helping others with their tickets offers you a daily opportunity to live that value. When all higher priority items are under control (see Prioritizing work),

please look for ways to help other Support Engineers with their tickets, such as by engaging with your Support Pods, by contributing to senior help sessions, by contributing to crush sessions, by pairing on tickets, by looking for help requests in the various Slack channels, etc.

What does success look like?

Success will look like a healthy balance between solving your assigned support tickets and helping others to be successful. For your individual ticket work, you and your manager should begin with the following two criteria, the first quantitative and the second qualitative:

1. Review a sampling of your tickets with your manager in your regular 1:1 meetings. Look not only for evidence of your technical skills in solving the problem, but also at how you managed the ticket and worked with the customer. In addition to producing evidence of your level of success, these reviews should result in improvements to the quality of your ticket work, both technical and nontechnical.
1. Compare your weekly results against the three parts of the ticket baseline:

Ticket baseline

The ticket baseline is useful in gauging a Support Engineer's volume of ticket work compared to that of the rest of the global Support Team. We use a dynamic baseline that is equal to 85% of the mean for each metric. This dashboard shows the current values.

- Consider the baseline metrics as minima to be achieved each week
- When you don't meet a baseline, you and your manager should discuss in your next 1:1 meeting to determine what changes you should make, if any
- We believe in quality, not quantity. More is not necessarily better. GitLab gives you freedom to choose and trusts you to use good judgment in exercising that